

THE STOOLS STORY

The informal street food space Ngo Thoi Nhiem Street in Ho Chi Minh city

How does the street food vendor space reflect the diversity in Ho Chi Minh city and what are the underlying reactions government taking on it?

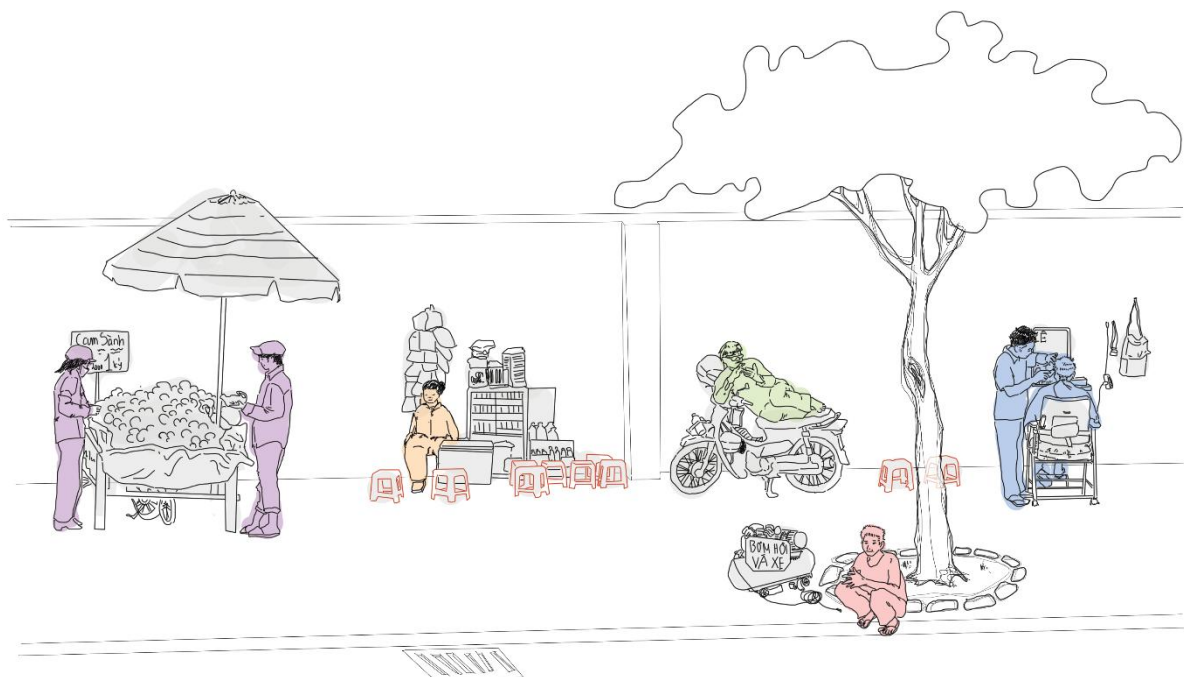
A look through the case of Ngo Thoi Nhiem Street

Hoang Ngoc Dieu Tran (Master in Urbanism, Landscape and Planning)

Diversity and Pluralism

Street food, Ho Chi Minh City, Viet Nam

The sidewalk space in Vietnam not only serves as a pathway for pedestrians or a buffer between vehicles and buildings but also as a mixed-use public space (Kim, 2015) with various daily (and usually informal) activities involving different inhabitants (Le, 2016). Some examples of these activities include barbering, bike-taxis, merchants, vendors, etc. These activities represent the sidewalk as a site of commerce for lower-income inhabitants (Kim, 2015), providing a facet of financial diversity in the city.



Food vendors – a specific kind of street vendor that serves food and drinks, often seen with a simple cart, double strickle, or sometimes just a pot and a few short stools – are a popular way for inhabitants to use the sidewalk space to make a living while fulfilling the demands of other hungry inhabitants. These stools are handy for the vendors to create a quick, drafty space for their customers to sit down and enjoy their meals, easy to clean up after serving hours within a few minutes (Mateo & Idea, 2007). They are convenient for accommodating the needs of the users or the space they have to work with: they could be used as sitting stools, tables, counters, or – on some occasions – as a way to mark their territories. These vendors are cheap and convenient, an affordable option for almost everyone.

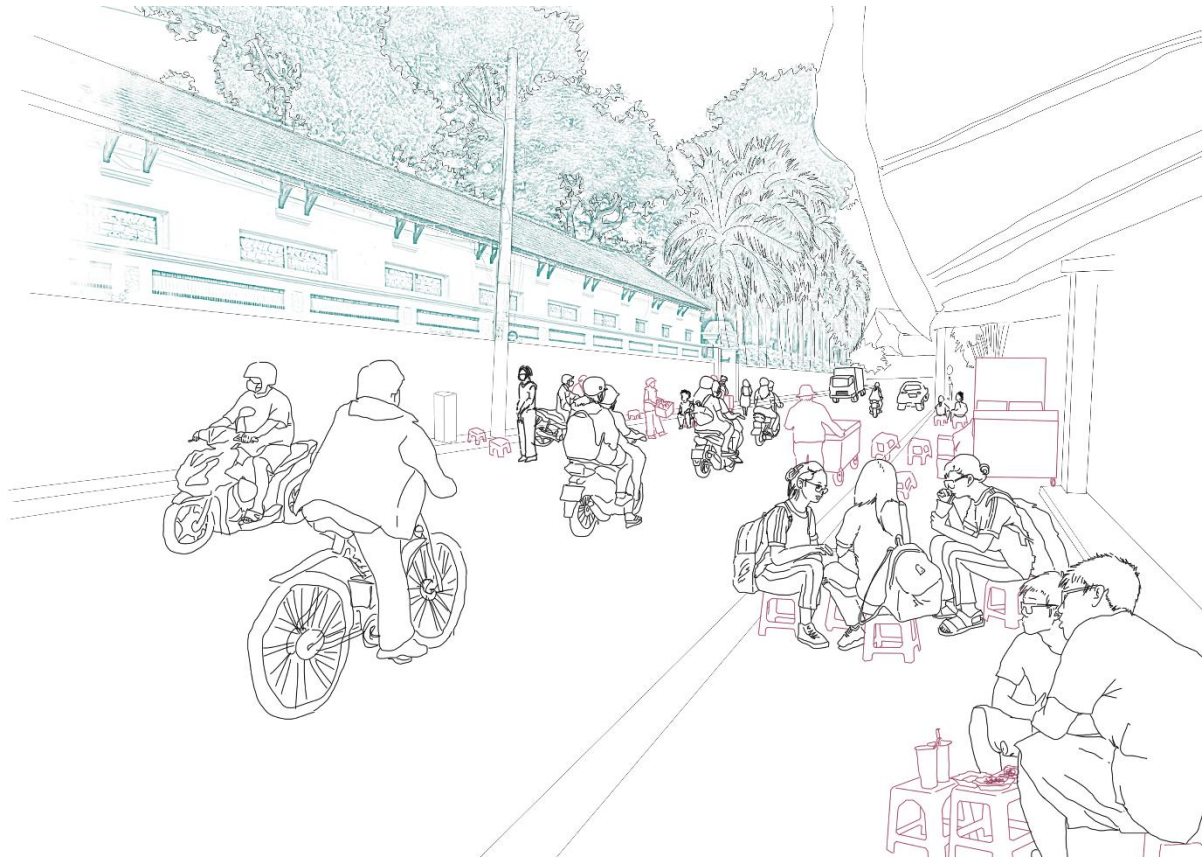


In the book “Urban Diversity: Space, Culture, and Inclusive”, the authors provided insights about the economic heterogeneity within cities, highlighting how disparities manifest spatially and socially, influencing access to opportunities and urban services. This economic diversity is reflected in the spatial organization of cities, where different social groups occupy, use, and transform urban spaces, creating a mosaic of neighborhoods with unique characteristics and challenges. They discuss the interplay between economic status and spatial dynamics, illustrating how affluent neighborhoods and informal activities coexist and interact within the urban fabric, shaping the overall structure and functionality of the city.



Look at a specific case of Ngo Thoi Nhiem Street – located between Marie Curie High School and a typical central street with stores, cafes, a residential alley, and a hotel. This particular section of the street is well-known for its food vendors and is also called “Ngo Thoi Nhiem Snack Street” on social media. The price for their portions varies from 10,000 VND to 25,000 VND (equivalent to 30 cents to 1 USD) in the 2010s (Dieu, 2017), which is about one hour of minimum wage during the same period (Nguyen, 2017). They might cost a bit more than similar portions in other residential districts but are still much cheaper than the cost of a meal

in Ho Chi Minh City center. Therefore, they are popular among students and lower-income customers for a quick meal or a good snack and chat time with friends.



The main customers for these vendors are Marie Curie High School students, which affects the vendors' active hours based on the students' schedule. The schedule not only has its own rhythm of use throughout the day and night but also on a seasonal basis (Amin, 2010). During weekdays, the space is much more active around mealtimes: breakfast, lunch, and late afternoon snack time. Saturdays are active evenly throughout the day, while Sundays and other holidays – especially Lunar New Year and summertime – are completely quiet. The active hours indeed clash with the city's rush hour when people are moving around the most. Due to the limited sidewalk space, the stools and stalls often spill into the road areas, between the bikes and cars. Despite this, the negotiations and transactions are conducted in a relatively efficient and safe manner (Amin, 2010).

Ngo Thoi Nhiem Street, like other streets marked by non-hierarchical relations and a surfeit of diversity (Amin, 2010), invites a variety of users. The vendors come in all shapes and sizes, as do the customers. This location is not only next to one of the biggest high schools in the city but also near many other schools, offices, and construction sites in a busy central district. Therefore, the customers could be students, office employees, construction workers, etc. This location also attracts influencers and even tourists who come to check out the vendors' offerings (Woossi, 2019), making the space even more colorful. While the vendors here still change over time—some come and go quickly, while others have made their names recognizable with their food products: Ut Trang milk tea, Giau beef stew, and Phuong stir-fried noodles. As Amin wrote

about the sense of “us,” these are "spaces where people who already know each other meet at known corners."



Students from Marie Curie highschool and nearby schools hanging out or having lunch.



Dating or casual meet up with friends



Workers looking for a cheap and quick meal



Tourist and influencers experience the space (Woossi - a Korean influencer)



Office employees grabbing a snack to-go

The customers



Ut Trang sisters milk-tea



Miss Giau stew beef



'Uncle grilled meat'



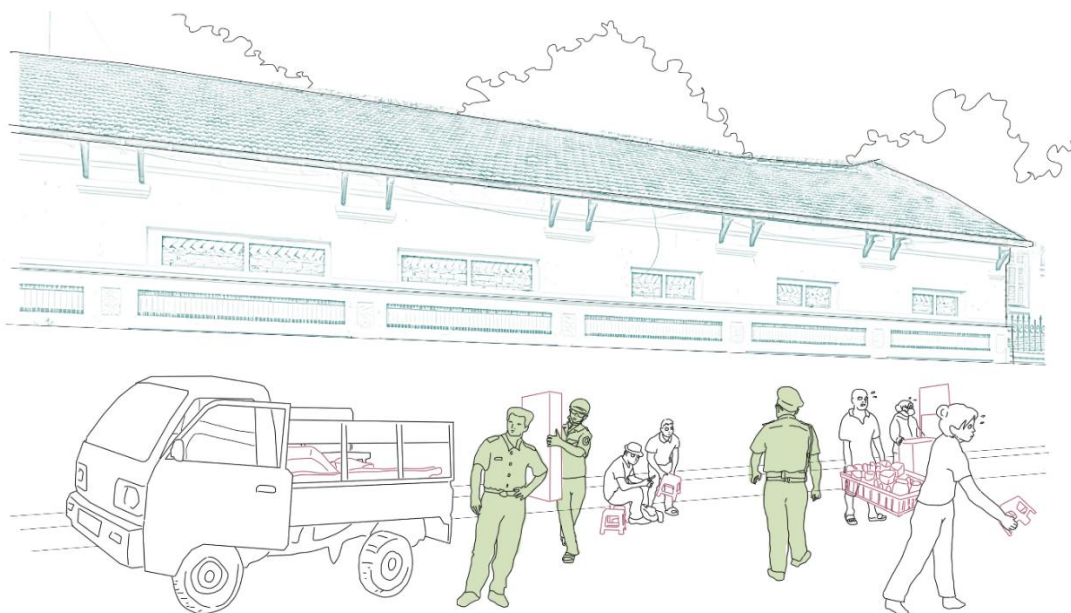
Phuong the stir-fried noodles lady



Phong Thuy soda

The vendors

Food vendors and street vendors in Vietnam provide convenience for daily life but also create challenges. Street sanitation, health and product hygiene, and transportation safety concerns are a few of the many issues that have been addressed through various media channels. Ho Chi Minh City has undertaken sidewalk clearance policies (Kim, 2015), attempting to “wipe them off” by confiscating the vendors’ stalls and stools, issuing fines, or sometimes even changing the design of the sidewalks to make it harder for the vendors to gather. Ngo Thoi Nhiem Street has gone through these periods, with government trucks chasing the vendors away. However, with their quick setup of stools and stalls, many times they managed to escape and return the space to its “clean” and “quiet” initial state.



No matter how many times the government tried to clear the street of vendors, they eventually returned. The reasons stem from both the demand for affordable meals and snacks from their customers and the vendors' need to make a living. Starting with just a bike and a food box, then one stool, two stools, and eventually many stools reappear. During the “intense” times, as a customer, you might have to join in the chase and run with the vendors in the middle of your meal.

When entering this kind of market, although it operates informally without any legal regulation, there are certain rules vendors must follow to sustain their business. What's known as “tax money” is actually bribery paid to two sides of the management system. The “black money” is paid to local gangs to prevent trouble and “protect” vendors from other vendors or potential overcrowding that could increase competition in the area. In contrast, “red money” is paid to corrupt local authorities who turn a blind eye to the vendors' activities or sometimes signal them during inspections (Le & Thanh, 2017). This issue has been recognized, and the government has taken steps to investigate and apprehend those involved in these crimes. The Vietnamese government is also working on a regulatory system to find alternatives to sidewalk spaces to address this issue.



After the construction of Mai House Saigon Hotel finished and it went into operation in 2020, the area has been cleared to maintain the front of the hotel and the side of the high school as “clean” spaces. The wall on Marie Curie High School's sidewalk has been rebuilt and combined with a vegetation facade, which, unfortunately, narrows the walkable space even though it improves the view and reduces odors from unwanted “street water”. Similar to the Lukasa case in 1999, vendors have relocated to alternative market locations (Stren, 2010), moving toward Le Quy Don Street – another area in front of Marie Curie High School – with their carts and stools, creating a new informal dining space with the same purpose. Some vendors still remain on Ngo Thoi Nhiem Street, with some transitioning into store setups using money saved from their long tenure in informal business, while others have downsized to just a bike and a box of supplies, increasing their mobility. Ultimately, eating is a basic human need, and affordable, convenient choices will always be favored. Where there's demand, there will be supply.

I grew up around these bustling street vendor spaces, although now I rarely get the chance to visit them. They are firmly tied to my memories of student life. Street vendor spaces, to me, mean more than just a place to eat; they were where we gathered, hung out, chatted, or simply took a break from busy city life. Despite challenges like sanitation, safety, and regulatory pressures, the persistence of these vendors underscores the essential role of economic necessity and adaptability within urban environments. These cheap and convenient options are invaluable, whether you're a low-income worker grabbing a quick meal between shifts or a student fueling up before night classes. When my friends ask if I want to visit Ngo Thoi Nhiem

Street, 15B Le Thanh Ton Alley, or 76 Hai Ba Trung Alley, it makes me feel a sense of belonging to this city. Perhaps we should not treat them as a “taboo” and try to erase them completely, but instead find a way to negotiate and give a fair chance to any dwellers who are looking for an opportunity in this unexpectedly elusive life. As Jane Jacobs said: “Lowly, un-purposeful, and random as they appear, sidewalk contacts are the small change from which a city's wealth of public life must grow.”

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All images were drawn/ modified by the author. Base photo resources:

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